

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1992-10-15

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,
2 ber 1992 and is very glad that you have raised this matter. it has recently
3 been disturbed at the degree to which these issues seem to have been giv-
4 ing concern to bahá'ís in different parts of the world. it may, indeed, be
5 providential for the matter to be brought to the fore now, before the english
6 translation of the kitáb-i-Aqdas is published. we have been asked to convey
7 to you the following comments.

As you know, the human soul is “a heavenly gem . . . whose mystery no

8 mind, however acute, can ever hope to unravel,” “one of the signs of god, 140.1

140.2139 7b

139 7c

139 8

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141 295a mystery among his mysteries.”140-1 if even the soul of man is so ineffable

142 a reality, how can a human being claim to understand or to set forth the

143 nature of the manifestations of god, of the relationships between Them, or

144 of Their relationship to god, let alone to grasp the nature of god himself?

145 bahá'u'lláh has explained these mysteries to a degree never before ap-

146 proached, but we must accept that they are realities that cannot be defined in a
rigorous manner, as one would attempt to define the terms of mathe-

147 matics or even of philosophy. This is a realm of knowledge in which poetry, analogy,
hyperbole and paradox are to be expected; a realm in which the manifestations Themselves
speak with many voices. undoubtedly you are

148 familiar with the passage in the kitáb-i-íqán in which bahá'u'lláh elaborates

this theme, commenting on muḥammad's statement: “Some of the Apostles

we have caused to excel the others. To some god hath spoken, some he

149 hath raised and exalted. And to jesus, Son of mary, we gave manifest signs,

and w e strengthened h im with the h oly Spirit.”

150 140-2

by virtue of this station, they have claimed for themselves the voice

151 of divinity and the like, whilst by virtue of their station of messeng-

ership, they have declared themselves the messengers of god. in every

152 instance they have voiced an utterance that would conform to the requirements of the occasion, and have ascribed all these declarations to Themselves, declarations ranging from the realm of divine revela-

tion to the realm of creation, and from the domain of divinity even

153 unto the domain of earthly existence. Thus it is that whatsoever be their utterance, whether it pertain to the realm of divinity, lordship,

prophethood, messengership, guardianship, Apostleship or Ser-

154 vitude, all is true, beyond the shadow of a doubt. Therefore, these sayings which we have quoted in support of our argument must be

155 attentively considered, that the divergent utterances of the manifesta-

tions of the unseen and daysprings of holiness may cease to agitate

156 the soul and perplex the mind.

157 140-3

158 140-1. gwb, nos. 82.1, 82.6.

159 140-2. gwb, no. 22.4.140-3. gwb, no. 22.10.140.3

140 3a

141 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

142 296The bahá'ís must study the kitáb-i-íqán and the explanations given by

143 ‘Abdu’l-b ahá and Shoghi effendi and not be misled into thinking that any

144 statement made in the Sacred Texts, in the writings of Shoghi effendi, or in

145 fundamental clarifications.

146 in the kitáb-i-Aqdas, bahá'u'lláh again and again speaks with the voice

147 of god, a station that h e affirms in this passage from the Súriy-i-h aykal:

Naught is seen in my temple but the Temple of god, and in my

beauty but his beauty, and in my being but his being, and in my
self but his Self, and in my movement but his movement, and in
148 my acquiescence but his Acquiescence, and in my pen but his pen,
the mighty, the All-p raised. There hath not been in my soul but the
T ruth, and in myself naught could be seen but god. . . . The holy
Spirit itself hath been generated through the agency of a single let-
ter revealed by this most great Spirit, if ye be of them that compre-
hend.140-4

149 At another time, as published in Gleanings I, h e wrote:

And whenever i chose to hold my peace and be still, lo, the voice of
the holy ghost, standing on my right hand, aroused me, and the
Supreme Spirit appeared before my face, and gabriel overshadowed
me, and the Spirit of glory stirred within my bosom, bidding me
arise and break my silence. if your hearing be purged and your ears
150 be attentive, ye will assuredly perceive that every limb of my body,
151 nay all the atoms of my being, proclaim and bear witness to this call: "god, besides
whom is none other god, and he, whose beauty is
152 now manifest, is the reflection of his glory unto all that are in heaven
and on earth."

153 in Messages to America, on p. 100, we find this illuminating statement:

it was in such dramatic circumstances, recalling the experience of
moses when face to face with the burning bush in the wilderness of

154 140-4. Sh, ¶44.140.4

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140 5a

140 5b

140 5c

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142 297Sinai, the successive visions of zoroaster, the opening of the heavens

and the descent of the dove upon christ in the jordan, the cry of gabriel heard by muḡammad in the cave of hira, and the dream of the báb, in which the blood of the imam ḡusayn touched and sanctified his lips, that bahá'u'lláh, he “around whom the point of the bayán hath revolved,” and the vehicle of the greatest revelation the world has yet seen, received the first intimation of his sublime mission, and that a ministry which, alike in its duration and fecundity, is unsurpassed in the religious history of mankind, was inaugurated. it was on that occasion that the “most great Spirit,” as designated by bahá'u'lláh himself, revealed itself to him, in the form of a “máiden,” and bade him “lift up” his “voice between earth and heaven”—that same Spirit which, in the zoroastrian, the mosaic, the christian, and muḡammadan dispensations, had been respectively symbolized by the “Sacred fire,” the “burning bush,” the “dove,” and the “Angel gabriel.”

146 140-5

147 on a related subject, the following reply to a question from an individual
148 believer was written on behalf of the guardian 19 october 1947:

bahá'u'lláh is not the intermediary between other manifestations and god. each has his own relation to the primal Source. but in the sense that bahá'u'lláh is the greatest manifestation to yet appear, the one who consummates the revelation of mooses, he was the one mooses conversed with in the burning bush. in other words bahá'u'lláh identifies the glory of the godhead on that occasion with himself. No distinction can be made amongst the prophets in the sense that They
149 all proceed from one source, and are of one essence. but Their stations
and functions in this world are different.140-6

150 it was with the magnitude of bahá'u'lláh's revelation in mind that the

151 universal house of justice referred to him as “the most precious being ever
152 to have drawn breath on this planet.”140-7 This is analogous to bahá’u’lláh’s
153 140-5. Tdh, no. 158.19.

154 140-6. Ig, no. 1552.140-7 . See no. 90, p. 160–67 .140.6

140 6a

140 7

141 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

142 298own statement in relation to the báb: “b ehold how great and lofty is his

143 station! his rank excelleth that of all the prophets and his revelation

transcendeth the comprehension and understanding of all their chosen

144 ones.”140-8 These are both allusions to that “distinction” which in no way

145 contradicts the essential “unity” of the manifestations of god, as referred to

146 by bahá’u’lláh in the kitáb-i-íqán:

147 conceive accordingly the distinction, variation, and unity character-istic of the
various m anifestations of holiness, that thou mayest com-

148 prehend the allusions made by the creator of all names and attributes to the mysteries
of distinction and unity, and discover the answer to thy question as to why that everlasting
beauty should have, at sundry

149 times, called h imself by different names and titles.

150 140-9

you may be quite confident that no “new theology” is being created—

151 such a development would be entirely impossible in the bahá’í faith. All

152 that is happening is that, in the year of the centenary of bahá’u’lláh’s Ascen-

153 sion, the bahá’í world is proclaiming more clearly than ever before the great-

154 ness of the event of his appearance in this world, and what it really means

155 to say that we are witnessing the coming of the kingdom of g od on earth.

156 it is likely that in dealing with such matters individual friends will go

157 beyond what the teachings of the faith justify, but such errors will in due

158 course be rectified and should not be permitted to give rise to disputations.

159 with loving b ahá’í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

160 140-8. wob, p. 125.
161 140-9. gwb, no. 13.6.140.7a
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142 299141

Responsibilities of Youth in the Bahá'í Community

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]